

Author: Adam Fistler, BCH – Behavioral Change Consultant (adam@adamfistler.com)

Positive Self-Talk vs. Negative Self-Talk

Self-talk is the ongoing internal conversation you have with yourself every day. It shapes how you feel, how you see yourself, and how you act.

Negative Self-Talk: Harsh, critical, and limiting. It focuses on flaws, failures, and worst-case scenarios.

- Examples:
 - “I’m going to fail again.”
 - “I’m worthless.”
 - “I can’t handle this without using.”
 - “Why even try? I always mess up.”
- This fuels anxiety, shame, depression, and cravings in recovery. It keeps people stuck in old patterns.

Positive Self-Talk: Supportive, compassionate, and realistic. It acknowledges difficulty but focuses on effort, growth, and solutions.

- Examples:
 - “This is hard, but I’m learning and getting stronger.”
 - “I’ve survived tough days before. I can do this.”
 - “One step at a time. Progress matters more than perfection.”

Positive self-talk builds resilience, self-worth, and the ability to pause between trigger and response — the same freedom meditation creates.

How Negative Self-Talk Connects to Belief Systems

Belief systems are the deep, often unconscious “rules” you hold about yourself, others, and the world. They are formed early in life through experiences, trauma, or repeated failures and stored in the subconscious mind.

Examples of limiting beliefs in recovery:

- “I’m broken and will always be an addict.”
- “I don’t deserve good things.”
- “If I feel bad, I must escape it immediately.”

How beliefs and emotions drive behavior:

1. Belief → Filters your perception of reality.
2. Belief triggers old stored emotions (shame, fear, anger, guilt).
3. Emotions create automatic urges or reactions.
4. You act in ways that “prove” the original belief (self-fulfilling prophecy).

This explains why you can **know** cognitively (“I need to stay sober”) but still **feel** and act differently. The emotional/subconscious mind is far stronger than willpower or logic alone.

The **Critical Factor** is the gatekeeper between your conscious mind (logic, willpower) and subconscious mind (beliefs, emotions, habits). It rejects new information that doesn’t match your existing beliefs. This is why simply talking about change or using pure logic often fails.

Meditation, hypnosis, and affirmations all help by gently bypassing the critical factor, allowing new beliefs and healthier patterns to take root.

How Affirmations Help

Affirmations are short, powerful, positive statements that you deliberately repeat to yourself. They are a form of **self-hypnosis** or **auto-suggestion** that helps reprogram your subconscious mind.

When repeated with emotion and belief (especially while relaxed, like after meditation), affirmations gradually replace old limiting beliefs with new empowering ones. They work through **repetition**, creating new neural pathways in the brain.

Rules for Creating Good Affirmations

1. **Keep Them Positive** The subconscious mind does **not** recognize negative words like “not,” “can’t,” “don’t,” “no,” or “never.” It focuses on the main image. **Classic example:** Don’t think of a pink elephant. (What did you just picture?) Bad: “I am not going to use drugs.” Good: “I am clean, clear, and free.”
2. **Use Present Tense (or Already Done)** The subconscious only knows “now.” Future tense keeps the goal always out of reach. Speak as if it is already true. Bad: “I will be clean” or “I am working on staying sober.” Good: “I am clean and sober.” Good: “I am healthy, strong, and living in freedom.” (Think of Jesus thanking God for already raising Lazarus — treating it as a foregone conclusion.)
3. **Be Specific** Vague statements give the subconscious nothing clear to work with. Bad: “Just do it” or “I am better.” Good: “I am a clean, healthy, and confident person who makes good choices every day.”

4. **Make Them Believable** If your mind reacts with “Yeah right!” the affirmation may be rejected by the critical factor. Start with statements that feel at least somewhat possible and grow into stronger ones as you see results.
5. **Use “You Are” if “I Am” Triggers Doubt** If “I am” feels too confrontational, try “You are...” This often reduces resistance.

Additional Tips for Maximum Effectiveness:

- Practice in front of a mirror, looking yourself in the eyes. Repeat each affirmation **three times, three times a day**.
- Best practice: Do affirmations during or right after meditation. In a calm meditative state, the critical factor is gently bypassed.
- Every night, journal specific things you noticed during the day that show your affirmations are working. Writing down this “evidence” turbo-charges the process.
- Before saying the affirmation, get the “feeling” of the affirmation you are saying. Example: If your affirmation regards confidence, remember a time you were really confident, and bring in a little of that feeling into your affirmation. It makes your affirmation more believable using an existing resource state, and more likely to bypass the Critical Factor.

Examples of Good Affirmations for Recovering Addicts

Core Recovery Affirmations

- “I am clean, sober, and free from all substances.”
- “I am safe, calm, and at peace in this moment.”
- “I am strong and capable of handling any craving.”
- “I release all shame from my past. I am worthy of a new life.”

Self-Worth & Identity

- “I am a valuable person worthy of love and respect.”
- “Every day I am becoming a healthier, happier version of myself.”
- “I trust myself and my ability to stay sober.”

Craving Management

- “This urge is temporary and I am bigger than any craving.”
- “I choose clarity and peace over temporary escape.”
- “My body and mind are healing more every single day.”
-

Emotional Healing

- “I safely release old pain and stored emotions.”
- “I am healing from my past and growing stronger.”
- “I forgive myself completely and move forward with love.”

Daily Strength

- “I am resilient. I recover quickly from setbacks.”
- “I make healthy choices that support my recovery.”
- “I am living a meaningful life in sobriety.”

“You Are” Versions (if needed)

- “You are clean, sober, and free.”
- “You are worthy of a peaceful and happy life.”
- “You are getting stronger every single day.”

How to Prevent Negative Self-Talk

1. Build awareness — Notice the thought as it arises (use the “Boats on the Shore” metaphor).
2. Challenge it — Ask: “Is this true? Is it helpful?”
3. Replace it — Immediately shift to a positive affirmation.
4. Practice daily with meditation and breathwork to create space before the thought spirals.

How to Use Affirmations in Your Practice

- Say them out loud in the mirror (3x, 3x daily).
- Repeat silently during or after meditation, especially in the Silent/Inner Layer.
- Combine with breath awareness: Inhale → Affirmation, Exhale → Feel it deeply.
- Record yourself saying them and listen back.
- Journal nightly evidence of progress.

Group Exercise Ideas

1. Awareness Share — Everyone shares one common negative thought.
2. Challenge & Flip — Group turns negative thoughts into positive affirmations.
3. Mirror Work — Practice affirmations in the mirror with eye contact.
4. Meditation + Affirmations — 5–10 minutes of breath or mantra meditation, followed by affirmations.
5. Pair Work — Take turns saying affirmations to each other.
6. Evidence Journal — Share one “win” from the week that supports a new belief.

Final Encouragement

You already have powerful meditation tools. Now you are adding the power of **language** to rewire your beliefs and emotions. Change doesn't happen by force — it happens through consistent, gentle repetition in a relaxed state.

Every time you catch negative self-talk and replace it with an affirmation, you are doing self-hypnosis.

Every time you meditate and observe your thoughts, you weaken old beliefs.

Together, these practices create real freedom.

You are not broken.

You are reprogramming.

Consistency beats perfection.

Keep showing up for yourself.

About the Author

Adam Fistler is a Behavioral Change Consultant, Board Certified Hypnotist, Certified 5-PATH® Hypnotist, and former owner of the Baltimore Hypnosis Center. A member of the International 5-PATH® Hypnosis Association and certified by the National Guild of Hypnotists, Adam has studied hypnosis, behavior change, and the relationship between thoughts, beliefs, emotions, and behavior for more than two decades.

His perspective is shaped by more than professional training. Adam has also lived through addiction and recovery firsthand, giving him a unique understanding of the struggle from both sides: as a practitioner who has helped others create change and as someone who has had to confront his own deeply ingrained patterns and beliefs.

During his own recovery, Adam returned to the principles of hypnosis, mindfulness, self-talk, and behavioral change that he had studied throughout his career. He discovered that recovery could be about more than simply managing cravings or avoiding relapse—it could also be an opportunity to understand the beliefs, emotional patterns, and experiences that had shaped his behavior.

Today, Adam combines his professional experience with the lessons of his own journey to help others explore the possibility of meaningful, lasting change. His approach is grounded in empathy, curiosity, practical tools, and the belief that people are more than the behaviors they are trying to overcome.